9

INTERACTING: TURNING CONNECTION AND COMMUNICATION INTO RESEARCH DATA

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Chapter 9 will focus on interactive data-collection operations. Interactive data is co-produced and elicited, rather than simply observed and recorded. Before detailing the elements of interactive data collection, the chapter will consider the nature of online engagement as the appropriate frame for ethnography, replacing the more perplexing former term drawn from traditional ethnography, 'participation'. The chapter will then present procedural operations under the general categories of interview, involvement, innovations, and informed consent. The appropriate way to conduct interviews will be covered, focusing especially on online interviews. After that, the chapter will discuss, describe, and provide examples of involvements, or naturalistic immersive interactions. Then, under the general name of innovative research approaches to interaction, it will discuss the use of research webpages, digital diaries, and mobile ethnography. The chapter's final section will provide the reader with a more exhaustive treatment of informed consent procedures in netnography.

INTERACTIVE DATA

Interactive data is co-produced or elicited, rather than simply observed and recorded. It is the product or artifact of some kind of deliberate interaction between the researcher, or research team, and someone or something else. Interactive data usually involves capturing the traces and recordings of that exchange, and there are specific procedural operations and ethical rules governing those exchanges.

Interactive data can be co-produced in one of three main ways. First, they can be the result of a capture of a naturalistic process which occurs in the context of a social media site. The second way you can co-produce interactive data is by asking questions of people in a formal interview situation that happens outside of the field context. There are also blended types of interaction data-collection operations that are both naturalistic and structured. These methods include the interactive research webpage, digital diaries, and mobile ethnography. As well, screen-sharing during interviews can also provide the combination of a structured but naturalistic questioning frame.

This chapter will distinguish between interviews, immersive interactions, and ostensibly innovative approaches such as research webpages, digital diaries, and mobile ethnographies. All of these techniques – interacting naturalistically on social media platforms, interviewing people, and gathering data from a customized research webpage – are more intrusive than investigative methods. Thus, they require additional levels of ethical assurance. In particular, they require the addition of procedures of researcher disclosure and the gathering of informed consent. The gaining of informed consent is included in this chapter, with an example of an informed consent form included for your convenience.

The chapter is organized into five discrete sections. The first section considers the nature of online engagement. Participation has been one of the core principles of ethnography, and yet its execution in netnography's data operations comes with a whole heap of confusion. By considering netnographic engagement as the appropriate frame, rather than ethnographic participation, this first section clarifies one of the approach's most vexing and contested procedural foundations. The next four sections consider elements of interactive data-collection operations. These procedural operations are considered under the general categories of interview, involvement, innovations, and informed consent. The next section of this chapter will overview the use of interview approaches to data-collection operations, emphasizing online interviews. After that, involvements, or naturalistic immersive interactions, will be considered. The chapter will then present innovative research approaches such as using research webpages, employing digital diaries, and using mobile ethnography. The final section offers a detailed look at informed consent procedures in netnography.

Overviewing Participation in Netnography

If netnography, like ethnography, is about participation as well as observation, then what is the right kind and amount of participation? This is one of the biggest questions and biggest debates within netnography. Providing a clear and comprehensive answer to this question, which is central to the pursuit of interactive data operations, is the topic of the next two subsections of this chapter.

First, we should have some background. Participation in ethnography is embodied, immediate, geographic, temporal, and intersubjective. In netnography, much of this involves working with communication technologies, and using their archival functions (in investigative operations) and connective ones (in interactive operation). As we will note in a section of a future chapter, terms like 'field site' have considerably less meaning in netnography than they do in ethnography. Data may be dispersed among many such sites, and thus the term 'data site', or 'data sites', may be more useful than thinking about a single field site. Observations in ethnography are usually completed in person and recounted later in fieldnotes, but in netnography they become more like data operations. People posting on Twitter, TikTok, or publicly on Pinterest, for example, may be more like a public than a community. They do not necessarily interact meaningfully with one another, but some players in the attention game will distribute their materials to a wide audience. These examples show how social media and online communities are not synonymous. Online gatherings such as the Whole Earth 'Lectronic Link, alt.coffee, MacRumors, and OpenAPS have existed, and some of them exist still. These online gatherings permit a type of communicative participation in a group that a number of online ethnographies have hailed as the essential condition of the work being ethnographic.

Thus, it should come as no surprise that netnographic research varies widely in terms of the way it defines and uses the practice of 'participation'. Costello et al. (2017) are probably the most thorough and focused in charting the shift from what they call 'human presence in netnographic studies' to 'non participatory (passive) approaches' (p. 1), or 'active versus passive netnography' (p. 6). Costello et al. (2017) are correct to point out that the justifications some researchers give for their approach are misguided. Arguing that not participating or mingling with people online somehow frees a netnography from bias is inaccurate – interaction is not a bias, it is a choice of data collection procedure. As a procedural choice, it comes with its own set of advantages and limitations. I completely agree with Costello et al. (2017: 7) that researchers' active online participation 'is admittedly neither always easy nor appropriate'.

In a comprehensive content analysis, Whalen (2018) found that a full 84% of all netnographies published in hospitality and tourism research used 'non-participative' methods, as opposed to 14% who used participant observational methods (with one study, constituting 1.6% of the sample of 63 articles, deemed an experiment). Although they did not perform a count, in their overview of the marketing literature on netnography,

Heinonen and Medberg (2018) noted that 'the vast majority of netnographic marketing studies adopt a passive observer position. This may not come as a surprise, as this position is the simplest, most convenient and most unobtrusive netnographic research approach.'

It seems then, that there is a spectrum of participation and observation that researchers regularly negotiate, and that much of the time in netnography this negotiation results in a type of engagement where direct communicative interaction with people is limited or non-existent. The majority of the netnographies studied in the above-mentioned overviews focus mainly or exclusively on investigative data-collection operations. A simple but urgent question then remains.

If participation is critical to ethnography, what is so ethnographic about a passive, lurking, observational netnography? The next two sections attempt to provide a complete answer to this question.

From Participation to Engagement

Participation means to take part and to share in. If we think about the online context as a community or a 'local' manifestation of a particular online (or cyber) culture, the siting of a field behind a screen, then participation would logically infer engagement in that particular context. To call something an ethnography, we would need to engage with people directly, in the interactive manner of an interview or online interaction. But what happens when the field site is a data site that intersects 14 different social media sites? What does participation mean in this context? What exactly are the researchers taking part and sharing in?

Engagement is a subtler concept. One can engage with an object or a person, occupying their attention or efforts. Engagement can also happen without an object or person. One can occupy oneself or become involved in an activity or a field. Gambetti and Graffigna (2010: 820) called this the 'co-creational, social sharing, interactive, collaborative and participative dimensions' of the concept of engagement. What does it mean to occupy oneself with data or a site of data? What are the fields that one becomes involved in? How would the researcher want to affect the field they are studying? Would it be enough to preoccupy or absorb the site fully, envelop it, concern oneself with interrelated interests, emotions, and commitments? Is it enough to engage only with the traces of people, rather than people themselves, for the sake of your netnography?

In ethnography, participation is important because it helps develop understanding that leads to better translation and more informed meaning-making. If ethnographers are expected to participate so that they can gain familiarity with the historical, social, and cultural contexts that they wish to understand and communicate, then it is those goals which matter most – and not the particular means used to arrive at them. Participation in ethnography leads to emic appreciation – an understanding of the contextualized subjective and intersubjective experience of particular groups of

persons. The terms 'emic' and 'etic' were proposed by a linguist to denote the difference between the way native speakers use their own language (phonemic) and the way outside researchers conceptualize that same language, as a phonetic construction (Franklin, 1996).

There is a long, rich history of nonparticipant observation in ethnographic fieldwork: 'In nonparticipant observation, the researcher observes and records naturalistic behavior but does not become a part of unfolding events' (Arnould and Wallendorf, 1994: 487). Where the researcher decides that introducing novice participants or new voices would be disruptive to focal aspects of cultural scripts, or detract from the quality of the data collected, then nonparticipant observation is preferred to participation. These concerns are exceptionally important in netnography, as past recounting of my own online entrée antics has emphasized (Kozinets, 2010: 75–9). There is, in fact, a long history of ethnographers recording trace processes (Webb et al., 1966) and using mechanical recordings of cultural behaviors, such as photographs and videotapes, as data (Worth and Adair, 1972).

There is a range of membership roles available to an ethnographer within a conceptual spectrum of full participation to complete nonparticipation. In netnography, these positions may not be as important as they are in traditional face-to-face ethnographies. That is because nonparticipant data tend to provide less access to participants' perceptions, values, internal states, and beliefs in ethnography. However, in netnography we are often dealing with the first-person expression of detailed expositions and even confessions. Ethnographers are concerned about maintaining an appropriate distance from cultural phenomena so that they can attend to actions and explanations that cultural natives take for granted (Wirth, 1964). But in netnography, because we are dealing with social media interactions, the types of phenomena studied tend to be less all-consuming and pervasive. The biggest common problems relating to nonparticipation in netnography and ethnography are related to the risks of 'describing surface similarities rather than accounting for cultural variation' (Arnould and Wallendorf, 1994: 489). These are problems of limited breadth that can be partially overcome by 'careful sampling and interpretation building' that aims for 'interpretive depth regarding sociocultural patterns of action' in both ethnography and netnography. The next section of this chapter provides some general guidelines.

Five Types of Netnographic Engagement

Netnography is more like a repertoire than a method: a list of skills, techniques, and devices that are employable for answering particular kinds of questions about technoculture, where we can think of technoculture as 'the various identities, practices, values, rituals, hierarchies, and other sources and structures of meanings that are influenced, created by, or expressed through technology consumption' (Kozinets, 2019b: xx). Netnography provides a set of procedural operations larger than anyone needs for any

particular project. It is a toolkit of methodological appliances from which you can pick and choose a range of appropriate research designs for different research problems.

Engagement strategies sit alongside interaction data-collection operations as an essential part of the netnographic toolkit. They represent qualitative choices along a spectrum of being highly involved with various aspects of the research, the site, and the participants, to being relatively less involved.

Before I describe the five forms of engagement, I want to position the question of netnographic engagement in relation to the extant literature. In their welcome problematizing of the question of participation, Costello et al. (2017: 6) term Alang and Fomotar's (2015) approach 'a passive stance' to netnography, noting that the authors 'describe their netnographic technique as "purely observational"'. However, we must also note that, beyond their methodological self-description, one of the authors 'accessed the forum on a daily basis over a three-month period to read messages and follow message threads. Observing online communication and interactions as they unfolded provided a deeper understanding of the purpose and content of the communication and informed the content analysis' (p. 24).

The everyday engagement for ninety days related by Alang and Fomotar is, in my view, a form of engagement or involvement. Reading messages in real time and following message threads is also an active type of engagement with the site and its messages. Seeking an understanding of purpose and content, as well as context, shows a similar commitment to an active stance. The results of their study bear the marks of these commitments. For this is no mere distanced content analysis of a forum, but a sensitive and emotionally moving portrayal of the intimate concerns and worries, the comings and goings, of lesbian mothers who are dealing with the challenges of postpartum depression. Intimate topics that the authors present and discuss include participants' suicidal thoughts, treating their babies aggressively when they cry, dealing with other mental health conditions such as anxiety, the medications they are taking, the stigma of their sexuality and mental illness, and their reluctance to seek treatment. It seems unnecessary for the authors to participate as lesbians, mothers, and postpartum depression sufferers – this is an unnecessarily restrictive standard. Similarly, the insights gained from observation possess sufficient breadth and depth to provide a compelling look at the phenomenon of interest: understanding the role of an online forum in postpartum depression, and investigating how the experiences that lesbian birth mothers share on the forum might help to inform practice, particularly that which focuses on gay and lesbian mental health issues.

In this section, I suggest five different types of engagement strategies that involve researchers' interactions with data, data sites, and people. These strategies help to ameliorate some of the concerns listed above about the possible superficiality and lack of interpretive depth of netnographic research. They also avoid the shallow usage of the term 'participation' to refer to posting potentially unwelcome, obstructive, and ethically dubious 'I'm a researcher who wants to ask some questions' messages on public social media sites. The five types of engagement strategies are intellectual,

cultural, historical, emotional, and social. In the points that follow, I briefly explain and develop these types of strategy.

- *Intellectual engagement strategies* involve a deliberate effort to gain a deeper conceptual understanding of relevant interests and information. This is a common form of scholarly engagement and could include questioning the meanings of particular ideas, the mapping of structures or relations, or the seeking of a more holistic understanding of information that others take for granted.
- *Cultural engagement strategies* are ways to attend to specific practices, such as the use of particular linguistic terms, symbols, rituals, and acronyms. Cultural engagement strategies quest for deeper understanding of those terms and symbols. These forms of engagement might be more than mental understandings. They could also include such things as preparing one's own food, if one was studying a foodie-based online phenomenon, or going to particular restaurants that one had read about online.
- *Historical engagement strategies* consider past trajectories, customs, traditions, myths, narratives, and even people involved with a particular topic, idea, platform, or group. Historical engagement means delving into the past of particular groups, platforms, sites, or phenomena, to understand why it is the way it is, the forces that constructed it, and where it might be going in the future.
- *Emotional engagement strategies* relate to a type of involvement in which the researcher attends to the feelings of those whose worlds and words are being investigated. Emotional involvement in a research project means that the researcher is also moved by the phenomenon and that she seeks to share this personal feeling. Just as one can be moved deeply by a book or film, reading the words and images of people on social media can be a deeply evocative experience.
- *Social engagement strategies* are the most obvious and direct form of strategy, and the closest to what is meant by participation in traditional ethnography. Social engagement means being involved in some way with the people, platform, and groups you are investigating. It means that you communicate with them, interact with them, and openly and ethically exchange ideas.

What you should take away from these three sections dedicated to the topic is the idea that engagement in netnography is a series of choices and matters of degrees, a placement of the researcher and their focus and attention along a spectrum of various forms of intellectual, social, and emotional involvement, rather than a unidimensional choice about posting to this or that social media platform or not. Understanding the multidimensionality of these choices is important, because they indicate you can

conduct a highly engaged netnography using only investigative data. However, should you choose to invoke social engagement strategies, and connect directly with research participants for the purposes of eliciting data, then you would be engaging in interaction data-collection operations that require additional ethical procedure safeguards. Those operations, their modalities, uses, and how to approach them are the focus of the rest of this chapter.

In the remainder of this chapter, we distinguish between interviews, immersive interactions, and ostensibly innovative approaches such as research webpages, digital diaries, and mobile ethnographies. All of these approaches are intrusive and thus require informed consent from participants. The next section of this chapter will overview the use of interview approaches to data-collection operations, emphasizing online interviews. After that, immersive interactions will be considered, then innovative research approaches, and finally, informed consent procedures.

INTERVIEW DATA-COLLECTION PROCEDURES

Interviews in Netnography

One of the goals of a netnography can be to provide access to participants' perceptions, values, internal states, and beliefs. We may need this insight in order to fully understand a particular cultural phenomenon. Perhaps there are particularly difficult-to-decipher terms, images, or stories that are clearly of importance to discussions online, but the key to fully decoding them remains elusive to us after months of investigative downloading. Or perhaps we find that we are creating a full description of a phenomenon, but believe that we are not yet able to sufficiently account for the complexity and dynamism of the various cultural worlds behind them as they are phenomenologically experienced by different types of people. Chapter 7 explained that for some purposes it is important to be able to choose, or to confirm with certainty, exactly whose perspectives are being represented on particular sites. For all of these reasons, interviews have been found to be a useful part of the netnographic inquiry process.

Heinonen and Medberg (2018) found that published netnographies often contain interactive, question-asking data-collection methods such as interviews, surveys, experiments, or diaries. Although we currently lack a published account that looks at the question, a content analysis that I conducted indicated that almost 60% of published netnographies combine investigative data collection operations with other qualitative or quantitative data collection methods. Of those that combine methods, 52% combined investigation with some form of interview.

Interviews in netnography can take place online through a synchronous video teleconferencing program like Skype, Google Hangouts, or FaceTime. They can occur

using VOIP in voice-only form, like a phone call. They can also happen in person, asynchronously through email, through posting to a forum or webpage, or through other means. You can choose to interview a person of interest that you may have already met through social media as part of a research project. Alternatively, you might interview someone who you choose for their group membership or identity characteristics, and then ask them about their social media views, preferences, habits, and stories. Interviews conducted in person or with video aid (such as screen sharing) can also involve select persons who then guide the researcher in an accompanied manner into their personal neighborhood of online spaces.

Interviews in netnography can be group-based or individual, formal or informal, structured or unstructured. You also have your choice of multiple formats to conduct the interview. Synchronous interviewing online tends to follow a pattern that is familiar to in-person interviews. Asynchronous interviews are more like open-ended surveys. The remainder of this section offers some general guidelines for conducting online interviews. This short but wide-ranging section will be covering research focus, rigour, interview length, sampling, insider/outsider status, structured/unstructured interview forms, text versus spoken-word interviews, synchronous and asynchronous interviews, using visuals, screen-sharing, and recording and saving data.

Conducting Online Interviews

Salmons (2011: 5) defines online interviews or 'e-interviews' as 'in-depth interviews conducted using CMC [computer-mediated communication]'. Online interviewing has much in common with interviewing in general. It involves formally approaching a participant, suggesting an interview, and conducting a conversation from the frame of an interview, where the researcher's role is primarily that of the asker of questions (see Gubrium and Holstein, 2001). Online interviews are a form of primary, original, data gathering. They must be conducted in accordance with accepted ethical research guidelines. In them, verifiable research participants provide informed consent before participating in the interview. And, as Salmons (2011) notes, they should be conducted rigorously in relation to a research focus and question. You should try to match the objectives of the interview to the interviewee and the online platform (if you are using one). Interviews should also be pursued with some consistency in regard to execution. For instance, if you decide to conduct online interviews via a teleconferencing program such as Skype, it can be important for you to conduct all similar interviews this way in order to maximize comparability. You need not turn perfectly consistent interviews into a hobgoblin; just keep in mind that as you change contexts (e.g., more or less visual and personal) you also may be altering the kind of interview data you elicit or fail to elicit.

Long interviews might be difficult to obtain within certain sites, such as social networking sites or virtual worlds, where culture members are too busy to stop

for one or two hours to be interviewed. That length of interview can be difficult even for motivated and compensated online participants. If your informational needs are focused, shorter interviews of ten to thirty minutes can be effective. Sometimes, a quick exchange of information may suffice to inform your research question and focus.

Because interviews and other interactive data-collection methods are often used to overcome some of the challenges of anonymous, pseudonymous, or dubious online identities, sampling concerns can be paramount. Salmons (2009) discusses two sample frames for online interview research. In nomination, the identity and appropriateness of potential interview participants is verified by someone who knows them and who the researcher deems dependable. Using existing sampling frames, such as administrative records or membership lists, relies on verification by membership of a particular group (such as an online Facebook group, for example) or organization (e.g., the moderator or administrator of a particular YouTube channel).

Researchers can position themselves either as insiders or outsiders in relation to the online phenomenon they are studying. The choice of position depends upon the nature of engagement in the project, as well as the type of information that the researcher hopes to gather in the interview. For example, if the researcher is interested in deciphering already-discovered insider languages and meanings, then they would likely be positioned as an insider. If the researcher is still mapping out the general contours of the phenomenon of interest with the aid of the interview participant, then they would position themselves in the interview as an outsider.

There is also a broad range of positions that the researcher can position the interview along in relation to how structured versus unstructured it is. It can be useful to think in advance about how the technical medium of the interview changes the flow and opens up new interrogatory opportunities (or not, in the case of in-person interviews). The interview can be a wide-open conversation, a series of questions with limited choice answers (like a survey), open-ended questions that are asked of everyone in the same sequence, using similar prompts, with varied sequences, using original and impromptu prompts, or be run as an overview in which the interviewer suggests broad themes but the actual sequence is largely determined by the interviewee. Any of these are possible, but the more unstructured and free-flowing the interview, the more a richer media technology, like video teleconferencing, will be required to maximize comprehension and effectiveness. More limited media, like text chats, might be more effective when there is a limited range and focus of questions and answers. Similarly, real-time exchanges are more effective if the interviewer hopes for spontaneous moments of revelation, whereas the answers in asynchronous interviews tend to be more deliberate and calculated. The more structured the approach to the interview, the more important it is for you to use a carefully constructed, pretested, and revised interview guide (which is often called a 'discussion guide').

Text interviews tend to be different in many ways from spoken-word interviews – and current text affordance such as emojis offer a range of new expression modalities. In fact, because the online environment is such a visual medium, using visual images in your netnographic interviews is encouraged. You can try showing your participant a meme that is popular on their platform, and ask them to explain it. Show them someone's avatar, or a recent Instagram post. You can also ask them to express an idea visually. Have them choose a particular kind of image, or sketch something to represent a specific idea, and then send it to you. Visual or graphical exchanges can offer participants a type of projective that helps them express a tacit and unspoken level of understanding. Receiving and decoding such non-textual information can enable the researcher to access knowledge and feelings that participants may find difficult or awkward to articulate verbally.

Online interviews can also include screen sharing, which opens up another world of possibilities. Through sharing their screens, interview participants will be able to show the researcher activities online, rather than merely relating these verbally. You might want to have participants go to a particular online platform and do something specific, in order to show you the behavior with all of its nuance. Then, you can employ a type of verbal protocol to have them explain what they are doing, and explain or translate it for you. You may also want to observe them as they are performing online actions, such as installing a new application or using an unfamiliar webpage or program. Body language and facial expressions might be helpful observations for you to collect as they provide their narration or explanation.

Saving the data from an interview can happen in many ways. Skype and some of the other video teleconferencing programs now allow you to save your conversations, which is an enormous benefit. You can also record your online interviews with a voice recorder (or the voice recorder function of your mobile phone). Taking notes is always a good idea to capture your own fleeting impressions and visual observations, as well as to capture future questions you may want to ask without interrupting the current flow. A screen-recording program like Camtasia, for example, captures Skype or Google Hangout interviews effortlessly. This means that the researcher can be freed from routine note-taking or transcription concerns to concentrate fully upon the interview and rapport.

These are some general guidelines to conducting online interviews, covering topics such as focus, rigour, length, sampling, insider/outsider, structured/unstructured, text/spoken word, synchronous/asynchronous, visuals, screen-sharing, the format of the interview, and recording and saving data. At this point in your thinking, you might consider some of your options and begin to plan your interactive data collection. Box 9.1 can help you build that interview blueprint. The section following continues the discussion, offering additional guidelines regarding asking questions in interviews.

PLANNING YOUR INTERVIEW (PROJECT EXERCISE)

9.1

When planning your interview, you have a range of questions to consider about your approach and sampling before you begin to refine and develop your set of interview questions (which Box 9.2 will guide you through).

First, think about your RESEARCH FOCUS. What, in particular, do you want to discover from your interviews? You might write your answer here:

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Next, think about your SAMPLING FRAME. Who, exactly, do you want to interview? How will you recruit the right people for your study?

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Next, consider the FORMAT of your interview. Will it be structured or semi-structured? If semi-structured, exactly what will that mean?

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Will this interview be online or in person? .....

Will the interview be textual or videoconference? .....

Synchronous or asynchronous? .....

Will you adopt an insider or an outsider position? .....

Will the interview use projectives and screen-sharing? .....

What will the approximate LENGTH (in time) of the interview be? .....

How will you RECORD the interview? .....

Answering these initial questions will provide an excellent first draft of a plan you can continue to think about, revise, and polish as you begin working on your interview guide.

Asking Good Interview Questions (and Giving Good Prompts)

Good interviews always have an opening, a set of questions, and then a closing. The opening to the interview should explain the study, its focus and purpose, establish the procedures for the interview, and try to gain some rapport with the participant. Questions in the interview can be broad or narrow, and often are both. Broad questions help the researcher to identify and scope out relevant issues and their various dimensions. Probes are used to explore detail and help the researcher gain a fuller description of interesting phenomena.

Several kinds of interview questions are described by Patton (2002):

- Background questions (which are good for openings). For example, 'Can you tell me a bit about yourself? Where did you grow up?'
- Sensory questions. For example, 'How would you describe your typical experience on Facebook? What do you look for? What do you notice?'
- Opinion and values questions. For example, 'What do you think about Facebook as a corporation? Is Facebook a good company or a bad one?'
- Knowledge questions. For example, 'What do you know about the recent security breach that happened at Facebook?'
- Feeling questions. For example, 'How do you feel about Facebook's privacy policies? What is your reaction to the latest news about Facebook's privacy breach?'
- Demographic questions (usually asked when closing the interview). For example, 'What is your age? What is your occupation?'

Patton (2002: 372) also suggests several prompts (also called probes) that ask for details as follow-up queries to the overall questions you ask. These prompts include the following who, what, where, when, and how types of question:

- Who else was on Facebook that time?
- What were you posting?
- Where did you see that meme?
- When did you start going to that website?
- How did that big flame war start?

Useful throughout the interview are summary or reflective statements that overview the main points of the interview as you see them, and then ask the interviewee if they

agree with your summary or reflections, and also if they would like to add additional points to them. The interview should be closed by transitioning out of interview mode with questions such as 'for the final question ...'. Here is some important advice. Don't stop recording until the window on your screen closes, the interviewee hangs up, or your participant physically leaves the room. Often, some of the best material is provided after the participant starts to relax as the interview is ending, but before it is actually over. As the interview is closing, I like to ask participants whether they have any questions for me. Because the interview has already been conducted, the researcher can be more forthright at that point about the focus of the research project, and sometimes this leads to further productive discussion.

Using these guidelines, you can construct your own interview guide. The project-based exercise you will find in Box 9.2 will guide you through the sections and steps of the process. Remember that throughout the depth interview, the astute and effective interviewer will be paying close attention, prompting for more information, volunteering some information to gain rapport and create a conversation tone, and asking clarifying questions. The interviewer is building rapport as well as collecting information, hoping for genuine disclosure, and – if the interview is semistructured – remaining aware of and open to pursuing segues and elaborations.

WRITING YOUR INTERVIEW GUIDE (PROJECT EXERCISE)

9.2

Thinking about the foci and formats you have decided to use in your interviews, apply the suggestions in this chapter to design a draft interview guide.

A. The Opening. The interview opening will happen after you go through the informed consent form with the interviewee, and the interviewee reads and signs the form. The interview guide opens with a section that explains your study, telling about its general focus and purpose. It also tells the interviewee how the interview will run. Finally, it may try to gain some rapport with the participant, perhaps by linking up the research to something personal, or by reassuring the interviewee that there are no wrong answers and what you are looking for in the interview is merely their opinions or impressions.

Try writing your interview opening here:

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B. The Questions. The question section is the heart of your interview. Depth interviews (which often run two or three hours in length) often start with a grand tour question such as 'tell me about yourself'. They then proceed to ask a number of questions about the topic of interest. Avoid complex or double-barreled questions. Be very clear what you are asking. Keep the questions open-ended – not yes or no. Having a nice natural flow between the questions is important. You do not want to write an interview guide that requires the participant to jarringly move backwards and forwards in time, or to consider a major issue, then a minor one, then back to the same major issue. Related topics should go together. Usually, the interview will begin with macro topics (such as asking about online habits), then become narrower (such as asking about which social networking sites are used) and then narrow into even finer topics (such as asking about Facebook and Facebook's privacy rules). Usually prompts or probes are included (often in brackets). Prompts are used to gain additional elaboration of answers.

Keeping in mind the many decisions you have made when you planned your interview in Box 9.1, write out the series of questions you will ask in the interview. It usually takes some careful thought and even more careful revision to get a smoothly flowing set of questions. After you have the questions, write out some probes to make sure you get good data for your most important questions.

Try writing your interview questions here:

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C. The Closing. The closing of the interview transitions the participant back to the non-interview social world. You might think about how to word some of your summary or reflective statements. You also might include in the closing any demographic types of questions that you may wish to ask, such as about age or socioeconomic class. Finally, it is customary to ask the interviewee if they would like to add, elaborate upon, or share anything that they believe is

relevant to the topic of the interview. You might also ask them if they want to know anything else about how their interview will be used, or how the information from the interview will be handled.

Try writing your interview closing here:

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INVOLVEMENT DATA-COLLECTION PROCEDURES

Explaining Involvement

Interviews are useful, but they are also intrusive and elicited. They remove participants from a naturalistic context in order to question them. They provide an artificial situation, a social script called 'an interview' with a questioner and an answerer. In attendance with this interview script are all sorts of expectations, assumptions, and behavioral subroutines (Alvesson, 2003). However, interviews are not the only operation we have to capture interactive data in netnography. A more in situ (in context) way to capture interactive data is to do so as part of an immersive interaction, which I term here an 'involvement'.

An involvement is a data capture of the researcher interacting online, in the social media field site, in as natural a manner as possible. As we observe online sites, we see that questioning and clarifying activities are commonplace. People are naturally curious and others helpful. They frequently ask each other what something means or what someone does. They share problems and ask what to do. Asking questions and gaining answers online is a normal part of online behavior, and thus can seem fairly unobtrusive. As you conduct your netnography on a site such as Facebook, YouTube, Reddit, or Pinterest, you will find many opportunities to interact with the system, and with other people and agents using that system. You can comment on a post, or post something yourself and wait for comments. When you save those comments and posts, those 'involvements', they become interactive data.

What happens when a researcher posts a question online as a part of their netnography? This is an involvement and is also a form of intentional intrusion. That researcher interaction is, however well-intentional and justified, a subversion of the ongoing flow of the conversation of that group of people using the media. As such,

it may not always be welcome. It may seem natural and be very much in the flow of the regular question and answer of the platform. But because you are a researcher, and you are asking these questions not only for yourself, but also for the purposes of research which you hope to publish and publicize later, it is not actually natural. It falls under a different set of rules.

Chapter 7's section about researcher disclosure is very clear. If you are interacting in a social media context for purposes relating to data gathering for your research project, you must disclose your identity, affiliation, and purpose. If you have been spending significant time doing the deep hanging out that characterizes ethnography, and feel like you are actually a cultural insider, you might be tempted to hide your researcher identity and simply squeeze in a few questions. However, that would be an ethical breach.

Thus, disclosing your identity as a researcher is *de rigueur* when you undertake involvement-based data-collection operations. That disclosure inevitably changes things. In that particular conversation or thread, or for that particular group, this is no longer a group of people (and those inevitably playing the troll role) who are communicating for reasons of interest and passion. When you enter as a researcher, this has become your workplace. And those people have become your experimental subjects. Or, as one ethnographic participant once called himself to me, your 'guinea pig'. That places your questions and your presence in a precarious and unnatural position. It also creates a range of quandaries regarding the answers you might gather.

Reading the extant netnography literature, I rarely find involvement-based data being shared in final reports. Researchers often indicate that they have participated in the ongoing events of particular sites and platforms. However, when they have questions and answers with people, these are usually reported as interviews of one kind or another. I suspect that one of the reasons for this absence is that involvement operations are most commonly used to solicit interviews. I fairly frequently see researchers posting messages on social media sites saying something like 'My name is Jim Wilson from [something-something] University in Cityville and I'm researching cat memes. I want you to do an interview with me and answer these seventeen questions ... .' Although this sort of post overtly violates no ethical rules (we can see it involves researcher disclosure and at least approaches informed consent), it is disruptive to the normal business of the people using these sites, offers them very little in return for their time and effort and, in my experience, is rarely successful.

Involvement data-collection operations are best used judiciously, cautiously, or, my preference, rarely if ever. They seem to fit best with certain kinds of netnography projects, ones where the data site is more like an ethnographic field, where there are communal sorts of ties and boundaries. In that case, if the researcher takes the time to get closely involved with the ongoing interactions in the site and is, as Davis (2010) was with her Indian migrant online group, a recognized and respected member, then considering posting some questions or initiating a deeper discussion in an organic way might be a useful data-gathering option. This is, as you may notice, a long-term

immersive strategy that fits with a more communal social media atmosphere. For most data-gathering needs, however, a shorter-term procedure such as interviewing might be more efficient. For those that require a more contextualized consideration, one that can both question and have the participant consider their online behaviors and feeling in context, there are what I call 'innovative interaction-based operations'. Although there are conceivably many of these types of novel operations, this chapter considers three of them: research webpages, digital diaries, and mobile ethnography. These will be considered in turn in the following sections.

INNOVATIVE DATA-COLLECTION PROCEDURES

Just about every year, the word 'innovation' appears at the top of the list of various magazines' most overused business buzzwords. In research, as in business, novelty is perennially and simultaneously both celebrated and despised. As an ostensibly novel method, netnography has gotten its share of applause and rotten tomatoes by its neologistic links to innovation. Yet it would be difficult to deny that newness is valuable in research. Replication research, which is highly necessary to the progress of knowledge, is consistently missing in action. Researchers are required to prove the novelty of their contribution through their sophisticated positioning of ever-advancing theory. And especially in digital research which is, by its nature, often dealing with new platforms, programs, and modes of data collection, much of what we are creating and trying to apply is actually new to the world.

Thus it is with awareness both of the connotative and denotative aspects of the term, along with a slight congenital tendency to hyperbolize, that I term these interactive procedures for collecting data in netnography 'innovative'. Although I recognize that all three of them are based on established approaches, they are each still very new and have been used by relatively few researchers. Each of them can also be an entire research method or procedure in and of itself (the same is of course true of interviews). These are intentionally short introduction and overview sections, and are not intended as comprehensive procedural guides (like much of the rest of this book). They contain a few citations that will help the interested researcher find their bearings in relation to the topic. The following sections cover in turn research webpages, digital diaries, and mobile ethnography.

Research Webpages

A research webpage (or research website) is a dedicated online page or site that provides a select set of people with a set of questions or a research focus for the purpose of collecting data about a particular topic. The impetus for creating a research

webpage is that it contains the following properties which, considered in their entirety, are unique to this modality:

1. It is an online site and can blend into the 'natural' environment of online discourse and sites.
2. It does not interfere with the conversation on other domains or sites.
3. It offers an opportunity to invite particular people on interest to participate in greater detail in the research project.
4. It provides a dedicated online format to ask questions and elicit responses.
5. It gives clear information about the researcher and research project, thus satisfying ethical requirements for disclosure and informed consent.
6. It can present information and images that are interesting, useful, and/or amusing to research participants, thus giving something potentially meaningful back to them, or paying their contributions forward.

Although I have created and utilized research webpages for some of my own past research projects (for example, Kozinets, 2001; Kozinets et al., 2017), such use is still rather infrequent among extant netnography-based publications. The reason for this may be that people prefer other methods. Most seem to opt for more investigative modes of data collection, rather than involve any interactive data operations. Or it could also be that people do not realize how simple they now are to create, or how powerful they can be as a way to broaden your netnography.

Some simple guidelines follow. The site's landing page can introduce the research team, or individual researcher, as well as the research project itself. As you would expect, those introductions should always be completely open and honest in their disclosures of identity, affiliation (e.g., your university), and the purpose of your research. However, as with your introduction of the research project and purpose in any interactive operation (such as an interview), this preface need not be so detailed in its explanations that it divulges precisely what you seek to find out. That would be poor technique.

You can steer people to the site through invitation. These invitations can be very politely worded, apologetic-for-the-interruption, relevant, and public posts on sites that interest you. They can be direct messages or posts to people you would like to reach. You could make a YouTube video or meme about the site and then circulate it. You could even purchase advertising promoting your research website and targeting it at the right kind of person, if you wish. There are numerous ways that you can publicize the site to relevant individuals. I would expect that the number of participants who would organically respond (i.e., without advertising prompts or compensation of any kind) to a typical research webpage would compare to the typical lower end of the total number of participants you would seek in-depth interviews. These unpromoted

pages would likely gather varying amounts of more detailed data from ten to thirty different individuals, and usually not much more than that. With advertising and payment, I would expect that these numbers could rise to survey-like numbers, but the quality of some of the data would likely decline.

I like the idea of using the research webpage as an opportunity to give something back. If this is a relatively cohesive group, like a fan group, aficionados, or technology enthusiasts, you might consider providing some unique images or overviews that should interest the people you are trying to reach. For example, you could provide past research on the topic (i.e., the interesting parts of your lit review, reworded to be generally readable). You could offer entry to a lottery with a prize for those who contribute, or contribute 'meaningfully', to the site.

Then, the page should ask its questions. Because you are not going to be present as you would be in an interview to elaborate or explain these when they are confusing, you should ensure that the questions you provide are worded in the clearest manner possible. You may want to pretest them with real people (rather than fellow academics or students). You must then offer a way for participants to respond. Responses often come through filling in boxes on the webpage. But they could also come via email, through scheduling an interview using a video teleconferencing platform, or as social media direct message responses. A very nice feature of the research webpage is that it persists. You can comment right on the page, asking for additional detail, clarifying misconceptions, or extending new questions. I will note here, and have noted before, that Facebook offers very convenient pages that easily handle all of these tasks. Box 9.3 guides you through the creation of a Facebook-based research webpage.

CREATING A RESEARCH WEBPAGE ON FACEBOOK (PROJECT EXERCISE)

9.3

Fortunately for netnographers working today, creating a research webpage on Facebook is a rather simple matter of pressing a few buttons and filling in a few forms. However, what you choose to say and who you choose to invite to your research webpage can prove a much more complex matter. In this project exercise, I will only deal with the technical aspects of creating the page. Those other more contingent and complex matters of research disclosure and sampling are covered in other sections in this book.

1. After first logging into Facebook, you will see a menu running vertically along the left-hand side of your browser (beneath the f-logo and the search bar). Under the category named 'Explore' is another category named 'Groups'. Click that category.

(Continued)

2. Once you are in the Groups section of Facebook, you will see your pending group invitations, and as you scroll down, your favorites and the groups you manage. At the top of this screen, just below the level of the search bar and on your right-hand side, you should see a green button that invites you to '+Create Group'. Click that green button.
3. A new box will open called 'Create New Group'. First, it asks you to name your group. So go ahead and name it. Then, it asks you to add some people. If you know who you want to add, then add them. You must add at least one person, so consider adding a friend or family member who won't mind being the first member of your group. The box also prompts you to select a privacy setting. The default is closed. You might also decide to make the group public, or secret. After completing your settings, click the 'Create' button on the bottom right.
4. Fill in your introduction. Find some nice image for your header to convey the feeling you would like to communicate. And then you are ready to start inviting participants, asking them questions, following up, and holding back-and-forth research-focused conversations with them as you like. It will take you only a few minutes (thank you Facebook), and your page should look something like the image I share below of the one I just created.

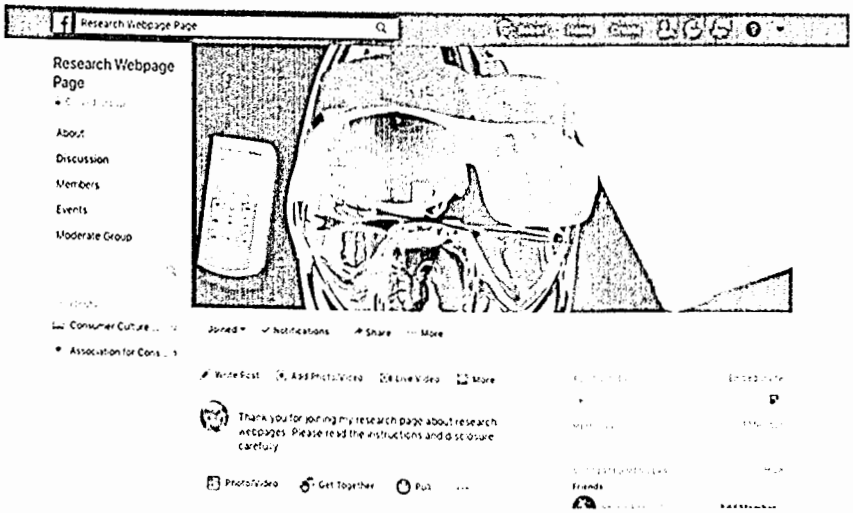

Figure 9.1 My Facebook research webpage

As Box 9.3 demonstrates, creating a Facebook-based research webpage is a fairly quick and easy matter. It can also provide viable data from a few dozen or so people with a minimum of effort. However, what if you want to do something more with the opportunity to create a research webpage? What if you aspire to create an entire site that not only helps you gather data for your research project, but is also a topically-focused, functioning, and viable conversational space for hundreds of even thousands of people? Wallace et al. (2018) went to elaborate lengths to create a website and an online community of practice to support healthy eating practices in early childhood education and care. They called it Supporting Nutrition for Australian Children, or SNAC for short. The site was both research webpage and action research enacted in the sphere of social media. Their insightful article provides a wealth of information to guide future researchers who want to use a full-on and sophisticated research webpage method in netnography. The authors found that initial recruitment, member engagement, and ongoing participation were challenges that they had to meet. Their contribution of the notion of 'netnographic slog' represents a term for the challenges they faced to recruit participants and enhance participation. Advanced knowledge of these challenges, and the viable solutions they devised to face them, is a very useful contribution that can assist anyone interested in building and using a research webpage in their netnography.

Digital Diaries

Another of the approaches most commonly combined with netnography in extant studies is the use of diary methods (Heinonen and Medberg, 2018). Diary methods, in which participants are asked to keep regular (usually daily) journals of their experiences as a means for collecting data, have a long history as useful tools of qualitative research. As Biraghi and Gambetti (2018) note, these diaries are often used as a complement to other techniques 'with the aim of getting a deeper glance into participants' daily practices and inner experience and to integrate and corroborate the thick descriptions' gained through the use of other methods such as interviews or ethnography.

In their study of the online postings of an influential group of Chinese tourists who use recreational vehicles to travel through Australia, Wu and Pearce (2014: 26) followed 22 Chinese blogs. Because these blogs tended to unfold temporally, the authors considered them to be like a 'digital diary'. The information provided in these digital diary-like social media posts was rich, and included:

> all aspects of travelling e.g., visa application, tickets booking, accommodation booking, car or RV renting, best restaurants, must see sights, must do activities, and many other issues. The blogs usually contain thousands of words and are accompanied by dozens, sometimes hundreds of photos.

Similarly, Leipämaa-Leskinen (2011) used a 'web diary' method to investigate how the web of cultural meanings surrounding and linking the body and identity is

constructed and negotiated in social interaction when dieting. Purposively sampling three diet-themed diary format blogs, the author conducted a netnography based solely on this dataset. The video blogs of combat veterans studied by Schuman et al. (2018) might also be similar, in that they studied posts in which specific people shared detailed information about aspects of their lives. These uses of blogs and vlogs as diary methods is especially interesting because it provides unsolicited data that is nonetheless relevant to the researchers' research questions. It combines the unobtrusiveness of investigative operations with the detail and direction of interactive procedures.

Diary methods can also be elicited and, in fact, this is how they are most commonly used. For example, in a study of the user experiences of female online gamblers, Wang (2018: 777) employed an online diary method which 'asked 101 players to submit online diary reports by LINE [a freeware communications application for smartphones, tablets, and computers] or email every week to make further observations'. The netnographer also participated in the PokerStars online game as a player (immersive engagement), interviewed participants, and did investigation-style data collection operations.

Digital diaries can use a variety of online platforms and devices. The core idea of a digital diary method is that the researcher either gathers naturally occurring and relevant diaries, or prompts particular participants to keep a diary on a particular topic of interest and that diary is shared online in a digital format. These diaries can include a variety of materials, such as photographs, video recordings, and sound files, as well as text. Biraghi and Gambetti (2018: 117) explain that they asked participants 'to share narratives about their individual experience and realities', and then those participants enthusiastically took control of the diary-writing process 'in terms of the type of data and contents they produced, contextualization of their stories and hypertextual connection with their social media'. The authors also crafted a 'diary guide' for participants similar to the interview guide in the prior section. However, they included a number of projective tasks designed to 'engage participants' storytelling impulse'. These tasks included collage creation, drawing, and structured fantasy exercises. At times, the authors describe the results as resembling 'sophisticated graphic novels'.

Like mobile ethnography (which will be discussed in the next section of this chapter), the digital diary affords participants a large degree of creativity and control over what they wish to represent and how they wish to represent it. Words, photographs, scanned images, memes, video recordings, transcripts of conversations, posts, links, and attachments are all options for self-expression. Also, like mobile ethnography, the diary unfolds temporally and locates the participant in space. If investigative data collection lacks a penetrating look into the inner world of the participant, and if that look is needed for deeper understanding of your research topic, digital diaries are an interactive data-collection operation that you might consider including in your study.

MOBILE ETHNOGRAPHY

In recent years, marketing research agencies and bloggers have begun talking about an allegedly new form of ethnography called mobile ethnography. Mobile ethnography is a form of research based on the use of mobile smartphones. Several new abilities are provided by the accessibility of smartphones, the camera on the phone, and the immediacy and telepresence of the research tasks. At the most basic level, mobile ethnography allows researchers to conduct interviews with participants using their mobile phone. These interviews can be synchronous, but more commonly they are textual or videotaped questions provided to the interviewee for them to answer on their own time.

Mobile ethnography tasks are used to provide a glimpse into research participants' lives, homes, workplaces, behaviors, and experiences. A mobile task might ask an informant to photograph the walls of their bedroom, their desk at work or school, or their bookshelf. Mobile tasks can also ask people to record themselves doing something. For example, a task can ask someone to record themselves driving a car or eating in a restaurant. In this way, the method allows for the collection of a type of observational data. The resulting recording becomes a product of the researchers' presence moving along with people in their lives. This opportunity can feel quite ethnographic – and rather extraordinary.

Capturing live feed from the screen of the mobile phone is also achievable. Therefore, direct observation of online behaviors becomes possible. Informants might be asked to view their Instagram feed as they normally would, or to sift through their Instagram feed as if they were looking for advice on dating. The traces of everything that they see on the screen and hear from the speaker would be recorded and thus captured as interactive data. This type of data can also be useful for understanding how people install and use new applications and other software, for purposes of hardware or software design or human–computer interaction theory.

Another type of mobile ethnography task might have the researcher ask informants to capture their reflections on a particular kind of experience as soon as possible after its occurrence. For instance, informants could be asked to record when their gender felt salient in the workplace. After a workplace incident happened in which they felt their gender was salient, they would be required to record a short video report about that incident, perhaps with attention both to external occurrences (events, people involved) as well as internal ones (thoughts and feelings). These sorts of critical incident technique-based methods have a long history in qualitative research methods. What mobile ethnography adds is that it leverages the practical ubiquity of smartphones to give easy assess to large numbers of people and the details and convenience of both still photography and audiovisual recording. The result is research studies that can combine the depth of qualitative methods with significant numbers of informants and control over sample selection.

Accessibility, immediacy, and audiovisual presence are strengths of mobile ethnography data-collection operations. Its limitations tend to be similar to those of interviews and other interaction methods. Combined with other data-collection operations,

mobile ethnography, like the other interactive data-collection procedures outlined in this chapter, holds the promise of enhancing netnographies with the voice of informants, enriching the study with a deeper phenomenological sense of the inner world of persons and their perspectives, as well as their physical surroundings, experiences and events, habits, and favored locations.

There are a number of different companies providing convenient and user-friendly platforms for hosting mobile ethnographies, such as Indeemo, Dscout, Mindswarms, and Over the Shoulder. Most of these companies also provide technical support as well as advice about which research procedures, as well as what types of questions and tasks may be more effective using the technique. With the three innovation operations now explained, we turn in the next section to a more detailed explanation of informed consent procedures in netnography.

WRITTEN CONSENT FOR INTERVIEWS AND OTHER INTERACTIONS

In this chapter, we have covered a range of interactive data-collection operations. In each of these operations – whether interview, involvement in social media conversations, or using a research webpage, digital diaries, or mobile ethnography – the participant is being asked to personally contribute data to the study. These interactions all clearly and directly meet the definition of human subjects research. As such, they are governed by the ethical rules of informed consent.

There is no need to debate whether it is ethical or even legal to record real-time interactions such as a chat interview without permission – the answer is no, it is immoral and unethical and may be illegal depending upon where and how it is done. Recording an interaction without participant permission and without researcher disclosure is completely unacceptable.

Interviews, whether conducted online or off, clearly fall into the area of an interaction and thus require informed consent. Interviews, whether conducted on your own site, group, or page, or through those of another, require clear informed consent that reveals the researcher, the research study, informs the participant about the use of their information, and asks about the level of protection desired. Interactions on a research webpage are similar, as are questions asked through digital diary or mobile ethnography formats.

Three questions are important:

1. Are the intended participants in the interview adults?
2. Are the intended research participants members of a vulnerable population?
3. Should the research be considered to have a higher-than-minimal risk of harming participants in some way?

If the research participants are children or vulnerable populations, special additional levels of assurance are required, just as they would be in person. If the research has some risks, perhaps because it seeks to expose some immoral or illegal behaviors, then additional information and assurances may be required. The starting point for all of these ethics procedures is the Informed Consent document.

The Reality of Gaining Consent

The simple reality of gaining consent, which I can also call a 'consent language game', is that online data structures do not work this way. Companies gain consent to host data. Some people never realize that their social media account settings are set by default to public. Many others want to compete in the social media ecosystem for followers and influence, a type of gamification. Shopping and the gamification of followers are ways that mobile phone technology has become indispensable to a new generation. As researchers, our studies focus mainly on those who share their data publicly. Some go private, which is a riskier and much more delicate data-collection operation, but often worthwhile.

Diminishing Possibility of Informed Consent

In a departure from traditional face-to-face methods like ethnography, focus groups, or personal interviews, investigative data collection in netnography uses cultural information that is not given specifically, in confidence, to the researcher. However, using this data comes with some ethical questions. In the early days of Internet research and Internet-based ethnographies, King (1996) recommended gaining additional informed consent from all online research participants. However, imagine trying to achieve that level of consent for the Twitter of today – it is impossible. That sort of advice is a relic of the bygone Age of Virtual Community in the 1990s, when King was writing, as Sugiura et al. (2017) note. Now, in the age of social media, there is absolutely no possibility that even a large and dedicated team of researchers could possibly get consent, for example, for all of the Twitter posters using the hashtag '#metoo'. Having to meet that impossible standard would shut down netnography and all social media research entirely.

Ethical Cultural Participants

When they interact and co-create social media data, netnographers are cultural participants. Perhaps the closest analogue to traditional ethnography that we find online, with its exotic locations and others, is the virtual world ethnography. Writing about the ethics of virtual world ethnography, 'we are obligated to do as much as possible to reveal to our informants the nature and purpose of our studies'

and also to keep them informed about the research as 'an ongoing imperative' (Boellstorff et al., 2012: 133). Yet exposing yourself as a netnographer can be a risky business, and may help account for the distancing drift of netnography away from more participative styles. Disclosure is difficult and intrusive and, especially in more localized and communal types of online settings, it changes the atmospherics of the research. If you act in a manner found to be irresponsible and disrespectful, that could lead to your public exposure and censure, and might even invite legal sanction.

Consent is a Liquid Concept

Informed consent for online work is one of the most vexing problems facing social media researchers, according to Sugiura et al. (2017). Zimmer (2010) analyzes the use of Facebook data in a multi-year, IRB-approved, NSF-funded study of a cohort of 1,700 university students. The author finds that the notion of what constitutes 'consent' within the context of divulging personal information in social networking spaces must be further explored. Consent needs to be reconsidered in light of the contextualized understanding of norms of information flow within specific spheres, which also reveals that we still have not learned the lessons of the AOL data release and similar instances where presumed anonymous datasets have been re-identified (Zimmer, 2010: 323). When we know that data can be traced, we are obligated to gain informed consent and to also attempt to make the data truly untraceable, if that is possible.

The Consent Form

Sometimes, online ethnographers have gone out of their way to ask for participants' informed consent to use their data. In a virtual world setting, one researcher approached participants asking for their 'blessing' for her project, and then presented them with links, an email, and a posting to a description of her research and an online consent form. Another researcher placed a halo over the head of her avatar to designate her role as an ethnographer (Boellstorff et al., 2012: 133–5).

A further way that consent can occur over the Internet is when research consent-related information is presented to the prospective research participant in some unobtrusive, electronic form. The participant might signal their consent by agreeing to continue in the study after reading a form or the text on a pop-up message and then clicking an 'accept' button on a webpage and/or by providing basic data such as their name and/or email. Salmons (2017) offers a number of useful examples of practical research suggestions for gaining informed consent that are based on contemporary practices. What is most important about these procedures is that there

must be some clearly defined activity that the participant must perform in order to signal that they understand and accept the terms of consent. It is common in netnography for the researcher of a particular community to post information about their status as a researcher and the purpose of their study on their profile and often on forum boards. This is not consent – this is disclosure. Simply posting a document and expecting that this grants you informed consent is, as Salmons (2017) underscores, insufficient.

We usually think about the consent process occurring at the beginning of a study, perhaps as we first begin to collect data. We might need to gain consent from companies, from moderators, from online system administrators, groups, individuals, or from parents or guardians of minors or other ostensibly vulnerable persons. There are many ways to obtain consent from participants, including print or digital signatures, virtual consent tokens, or click boxes. Buchanan and colleagues (2010) usefully contextualize the consent process by suggesting that, 'Sometimes it may be more ethical to get informed consent at the end when you want to present a specific case study or quote an individual or focus on a particular element. Therefore, informed consent should be always an inductive process.' This is excellent advice, but information online can be delicately ephemeral. If you wait until you are ready to present the work, in public or in an article, and then go back and talk to who you quoted, and ask them to make an informed consent decision, the link to them could already be dead. In academia, the publication time lags are sometimes not only measured in months, but in years. There may also be constraints that could render written consent impractical or even harmful. All of these contingencies should be considered.

Although questions have been raised about whether an informed consent approach can be valid without certain knowledge of the competency, comprehension, and even the age of the research participant, Walther (2002: 213) notes that many traditionally accepted methods such as mail and telephone surveys deal with the same sort of uncertain knowledge about whether people are actually who they say they are. In fact, there is no clear, indisputable link between face-to-face research and judgments of research participant competency and comprehension. Similarly, the fact that we have no steadfast guarantees that we can truly inform our participants about study risks should not deter us from doing our best to follow the required procedures.

Looking at the sample informed consent form presented in Box 9.4, you should be able to see many of the elements of the range of ethical procedures discussed thus far in this book, from disclosure to consent, risks, benefits, confidentiality, the rights of research participants, and data security. Using the sample informed consent form as a basic format, you might now try to fashion one of your own. If you work in a country and institution that require ethics approval, you should probably start that process sooner rather than later.

9.4

SAMPLE INFORMED CONSENT FORM

Letterhead: Your school. Or company, non-profit organization, or research agency. Full name of organization and address with phone number.

Research Project Title: Netnography of online utopian discourse (for example)

Principal Investigator: Dr. Robert V. Kozinets

Online Research Consent Form

You are being asked to be a participant/volunteer in a research study.

Purpose

The purpose of this research study is to examine the online experiences of utopian conversationalists. We hope to learn more about the experiences of people who participate in discussions on utopian videos as well as those who wish to participate in them, and to better understand the role of online interaction in social experiences and intentions. A research webpage has been constructed to inform people about the research and is available at www.youtubeutopianism.com/notyet/.

Procedures

If you decide to be part of this study, your participation will involve:

- Consenting to an interview to be conducted live by one of the principal researchers on Apple FaceTime.
- The interview will take approximately ninety minutes.
- The interview will focus on your activities on YouTube comments around particular videos, and some of your other related online and personal experiences.
- You will receive $250 in compensation for your time, and your results will be fully anonymized two years after first publication of the results.
- In the case of a face-to-face interview, the session will be audiotaped; telephone interviews will be audiotaped; online and email interviews will be saved for future reference. Data will be transcribed and may be quoted as text, with you assigned a pseudonym, in academic publications such as conference proceedings and peer-reviewed articles.
- After the two-year waiting period, there will be no way to link anything you say in the research to who you are. Even your demographic information can be hidden, if you like. All personal identifiers will be permanently deleted two years from the date of publication.

- Optionally, you consent to having your interview information appear in a table, anonymized, with your gender, age, and profession stated. Journal reviewers and editors will have access to the full original data digital files to review, but your name will be anonymized and the data will not link to your real identity.

Risks

The following risks may occur as a result of your participation in this study:

There are no foreseeable risks or discomforts in this study. The risk involved is no greater than those involved in daily activities such as speaking on the telephone or using email. Because some of the topic matter related to utopia may be sensitive, there is a chance that your recollections may become personal and emotional. This is all very useful as data, and so any shared reaction is a useful one.

Benefits

The following benefits to you are possible as a result of participating in the study:

You will gain $250 in cash payment. That is the main benefit. In addition, your participation in the study will contribute to our understanding of utopia and of online experience with utopias in social media.

Compensation

There is a $250 compensation for your participation in this research. It will be deposited into your account via Venmo, Paypal, or direct deposit.

Confidentiality

The following procedures will be followed in order to keep your personal information confidential:

To protect your confidentiality, your name will not appear in any publications. You will be assigned a pseudonym (a fake name) that will be used instead of your name to disguise your participation. In the case of quotes of things you have done online (such as posts on newsgroups or forums, blog entries or comments), we will change your quotes so that they are not vulnerable to being reverse-searched and identified.

We do not anticipate uncovering sensitive information about you in this research, but there will be a discussion of politics.

(Continued)

The data that we collect about you will be kept private to the fullest extent allowed by law. We are keeping all of this data on a single hard drive locked away in a secure location. To make sure that this research is being conducted in the proper way, the Human Research Ethics committee, or the GDPR compliance group, or the University or College IRB may have access to the research records.

In the case of electronic communications pertaining to online consent, you should be aware that this form is not being run from a remote 'secure' https server, such as the kind used to handle credit card transactions. There is therefore a small possibility that responses could be viewed by unauthorized individuals or parties, such as computer hackers.

Costs to You

Research participants should incur no cost as a result of consenting to be interviewed. You will gain $250 compensation.

Participant Rights

- Your participation in this study is voluntary. You are under no obligation to participate in the study.
- You have the right to change your mind and leave the study at any time without giving any reason and without any penalty. Either party can end the interview at any time. If we end before the interview is complete, you will be paid for the time up until the interview is ended, pro-rated for a 90-minute interview.
- Any new information that might make you change your mind about being in the study will be provided to you.
- You will be given a copy of this consent form to keep.
- You do not waive any of your legal rights by signing or agreeing to this consent form.

Questions about the study or your rights as a research participant

- If you have any questions about this research study, you may contact Dr. Robert Kozinets at +1 (XXX) XXX–XXXX
- If you have any questions about your rights as a research subject, you may contact Mr. Ricky Bobby, USC's IRB Co-ordinator at +1 (XXX) XXX–XXXX

Have you read the information on this page and do you agree to participate?

(Select one)

☐ I have read and understand this information and agree to participate.
☐ I do not want to participate.

Do you consent to having your anonymous (no name, no link to you) age, gender, profession, and income information shared in a table in the final document? Yes / No

Email address:

(required to confirm identity)

SUBMIT

THE ETHICS AUDIT

The idea of overview is important to ethical research. Even if it is simply to one's peers, the ethical procedures you follow for any particular project should be subject to your own summary presentation at regular stages that can be dictated roughly by the six movements and should be reviewed by others, whether on your team or people you find online for this purpose in different groups. The ethics audit can be quite formal, as in asking a peer group or institution to conduct a peer review of a research ethics plan or statement. The ethics audit is also a chance for decentralized peer networks to meet and organize using tools like LinkedIn and Facebook groups, and share their ethics plans for netnographies. This will be helpful for grad students and other students, especially as they learn netnography and develop it as a science customized to their fields, abilities, and interests. It is also a way to test new ideas and plans before the high-stakes process of the research review boards.

As you undertake this movement of your netnography, try to remember the key to interaction, which is the fusion of the horizons of people: cultures, groups, social media sites, groups of friends and families, romantic dyads of all sorts, shapes, sizes, and ages. This is the way Hermes comes: from the depths of our interactions, our activities, with verstehen, with understanding.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

In Chapter 9, you were taught about interactive data-collection operations. Interactive data is co-produced and elicited between two or more people, rather than simply observed and recorded. Before detailing the elements of interactive data collection, Chapter 9 considered the nature of online engagement as the appropriate frame for netnography, replacing the more perplexing term, 'participation'. Engagement runs the gamut from purely intellectual through to fully social and experiential.

Interaction has four categories within it: a) interview, b) involvement, c) innovations, and d) informed consent. How do you conduct interviews, especially online interviews? This chapter provides the answers. Next, involvements, which are naturalistic embedded interactions, were described. Then, 'innovative' research approaches to interaction: research webpages, digital diaries, and mobile ethnography. The chapter's final section offers a sample consent form. There will be more related material after you read about the final data collection movement in netnography, immersion.

KEY READINGS

Costello, Leesa, Marie-Louise McDermott, and Ruth Wallace (2017) 'Netnography: Range of practices, misperceptions, and missed opportunities', *International Journal of Qualitative Methods*, 16(1). 1609406917700647.

Salmons, Janet (2014) *Qualitative Online Interviews: Strategies, Design, and Skills*. London: Sage

Salmons, Janet (2017) 'Getting to yes: Informed consent in qualitative social media research', in Kandy Woodfield (ed.), *The Ethics of Online Research* (Advances in Research Ethics and Integrity, Volume 2) (pp. 109–34). Bingley: Emerald.

Wallace, Ruth, Leesa Costello, and Amanda Devine (2018) 'Netnographic slog: Creative elicitation strategies to encourage participation in an online community of practice for Early Education and Care', *International Journal of Qualitative Methods*, 17(1). 1609406918797796.